MIRTAZAPINE

Sedation & appetite ↑
Few sexual side effects

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-1,2,3,4,10,14b-hexahydro-2-methylpyrazino[2,1-a]pyrido[2,3-c][2]benzazepine
CLASS Noradrenergic and specific serotonergic antidepressant (NaSSA)
TRADE NAMES Remeron · Zispin SolTab · Mirtaz

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Major depression, especially with insomnia, poor appetite or weight loss.
- Off-label: anxiety, insomnia, appetite stimulation in elderly/palliative.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Blocks **presynaptic α2 autoreceptors** → ↑ NA and 5-HT release.
- Blocks **5-HT2, 5-HT3** (less nausea, sexual dysfunction) and **H1** (sedation, appetite).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** at bedtime; orodispersible tablet on tongue.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Sedation, increased appetite, weight gain.
- Dry mouth, dizziness.
- Oedema.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Agranulocytosis/neutropenia (rare); fever, sore throat.
- Hyponatraemia; suicidality.
- Restless legs; raised lipids; DRESS.

DOSAGES

- **Adult:** 15 mg at night, increase to 30–45 mg.
- Sedation is common, mainly in the first weeks; give at bedtime.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- MAOIs.
- **Caution:** hepatic/renal impairment, epilepsy, elderly.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, benzodiazepines:** ↑ sedation.
- **MAOIs, serotonergic drugs:** serotonin syndrome.
- **Warfarin:** ↑ INR.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** sleep/appetite within days; mood 1–4 weeks.
- Metabolised by CYP2D6, 1A2, 3A4.
- **t½:** 20–40 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Give at bedtime.
- Monitor weight, mood, sleep.
- Report fever/sore throat → CBC.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take at bedtime; may make you sleepy the next morning at first.
- Expect increased appetite.
- Report sore throat or fever.
- Avoid alcohol.

KEY POINTS

- NaSSA — α2 antagonist.
- Sedation, appetite, weight gain.
- 15–45 mg at night.
- Rare agranulocytosis.

SOURCES CHECKED **[792]** Mirtazapine 15 mg film-coated tablets (UK SmPC) **[793]** Mirtazapine, oral (US label) **[794]** Mirtazapine, oral (US label, Aphena Pharma)
Full references p. 432–457